



RAVISHANKAR

“

Our greatest success was when 42,000 women across five states became literate in just nine months.

KIRAN SHARMA,
Programme director, PACS

”

homes, most of which belonged to the poorest section of the villages. In Ramgarh, a village in the Chhattarpur district in Madhya Pradesh, women learned about the Right to Information Act (RTI) with the help of a PACS programme civil society organisation. It was the RTI that helped them find a solution to the severe water problem they were facing. Then there was the Musahir community that for the first time hoisted the national flag and invited the district collector for the salute.

Sharma remembers a particular meeting in Patna in April 2007. “That day, I saw 1,200 women who were elected as

TALKING HEADS: PACS at work in a Bihar panchayat

panchayat members from 22 of the poorest districts in Bihar gather in Gandhi Hall. The place was practically spilling out. One woman was carrying a child, another was carrying a sack, but they were all there,” she says. It was a goose-bump moment, Sharma says. But illiteracy, even there, seemed to be the biggest problem, she says. That’s why the Tara Akshar programme was put in place. Armed with laptops, NGOs went to the villages. Their aim was to educate women who had never even held a pen. “The greatest success was when 42,000 women across five states became literate in just nine months,” says Sharma.

The PACS programme finally came to an end this year. During the interim period before the next phase starts, Sharma says, a campaign to increase the reach and effectiveness of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme has been launched that will focus on around 400 villages. But, she says, the stories are many, each as inspirational as the others. “Listening to them, we feel we are finally making a difference.”